our reliable associates were to be found among fans of the rock group St Etienne, and fans of the writing of Philip K. Dick and Nabokov. There was no entry fee, though people could bring hardware and cables as a donation. Dress code: ‘1930s incognito is just fine’.

I can’t recall if the party quite lived up to my rhetoric. But all of my life at the time was there, in the invitation, if not at the event. Among these rather soulful wilderness years, I also learned to hate religion. I say hate, but I’m enough of a child of Aquarius not to want to hate anything. Let us say I learned in the period before going to university – my next move, to study Mathematics and Physics at Melbourne – the extent to which organised religion was probably a kind of evil. I would come to understand my dislike of religion to be a crucial part of my confidence. Take that as you will. I’m sure it’s true of many of us. I once ended up at a backpackers’ place filled with dozens of Christians from the Australian University Christian Convergence. Most were young women, and I turned, somewhat disgracefully, into a sort of Chesterton’s Hardy, the village atheist, while they tried to convert me with the rise and fall of their bosoms. One of the devout was the lovely daughter of a Newcastle minister. At some point in my unintended wooing of her, she looked up, fluttered her eyelids and said, ‘Oh, you know so much! I hardly know anything!’

‘That is why you believe in God,’ I explained. This conversational brutality appeared to take her breath away. It seemed I was exactly what she secretly longed for: a man willing to openly disagree with her father. A man, in other words, willing to be man enough, strong enough, the romance-writers might say (and I felt she’d read them), not to creep in supplication before her father’s God.

This, I’ll call the funny side of religion. The less funny side I found to be manifest amongst the Scientologists, the brain-burp of the late L. Ron Hubbard, which rakes in millions a year and is the acme of occultist thinking. As usual with such cults, they have found it advisable to keep their more wacko beliefs and practices out of the new recruits’ faces until the recruits are sufficiently wacko themselves, which can take years as the fresh blood works its way through the costly ‘levels’. The whole Scientology system breeds subservience and secrecy, the two things I was born to run from. I’m sure I have had my moments of bad judgement, but none of them can ever compete with the constant jet of nonsense coming from the Church of Scientology. I may be wrong, of course, and the earth is,